



SLOW RUNNINGS

WRITTEN & DIRECTED BY MATT POWELL



CANTERBURY CHILDREN'S THEATRE

SLOW RUNNINGS: A TORTOISE AND HARE STORY

by

Matt Powell

Matt Powell
027 368 3595
whoever@mattpowell.is

ACT I

SCENE 1

Outside a small, modest-looking house. A sign on the door reads "TORTOISE".

There is an uncomfortable silence. When this has gone on long enough, it goes on just a little longer, and then the front door of the house opens gradually, and out comes TORTOISE, moving painfully slowly.

TORTOISE makes his way to the front of the stage at a maddeningly slow pace (this should take up to a minute, depending on the size of the stage). He stretches his neck, clears his throat, and begins to speak:

TORTOISE: Goo--

But before he can say "--d morning", HARE races on from the side of the stage, pushes past TORTOISE, and begins handing out signed photos to the first few rows of the audience.

HARE: Hello, darlings! So wonderful to see you all. Here, this is for you... Sorry, I'd love to stay and chat, but you know how it is: got to rush! Love you all!

She goes to leave, but bumps into TORTOISE.

HARE: Oh, I'm sorry. I didn't see you there! Turtle, isn't it?

TORTOISE: Tortoise.

HARE: Turtle, Tortoise, what's the difference?

TORTOISE: Well, we're--

HARE: Anyway, you're interrupting! Can't you see I'm trying to talk to my fans?

TORTOISE: Fans?

HARE: Of course! They're here to see their idol, The

Fastest Animal Around: Hare, i.e. me. And you're in the way.

HARE makes a shooing motion.

TORTOISE: Oh. Sorry.

TORTOISE turns and starts to shuffle away.

HARE: Wait!

TORTOISE turns back.

TORTOISE: Yes?

HARE flashes him a winning smile.

HARE: Thanks for coming, Turtle.

She hands him a photograph.

TORTOISE: What's this for?

HARE: Well, it's for... you! To hang on your wall, or just, you know, look at.

TORTOISE: Oh, right. Hold on, then.

He rummages around in his pocket and produces a crumpled photograph of himself, which he holds out to HARE. She declines, gently enough.

HARE: No, Turtle, you don't understand: other animals want my photograph because I'm famous. Important. Highly regarded. Since I won my race against Cheetah this morning, I'm officially the Fastest Animal Around.

TORTOISE: She can't've been much good.

HARE: Who can't've?

TORTOISE: If she was a cheater and you still won.

HARE: No, she... Never mind. My point, Turtle, is that... Well, who's ever heard of Turtle?

TORTOISE: Tortoise.

HARE: Exactly.

TORTOISE: So I need to become famous somehow?

HARE: We don't all need to be famous. It's just better. Bye now!

HARE starts to leave.

TORTOISE braces himself to say:

TORTOISE: You haven't raced me.

HARE: What?

TORTOISE: How do you know you're the fastest animal around if you haven't raced me?

HARE: Well, because... I mean... well, you're a Turtle!

TORTOISE: I'm a Tortoise. And I don't think it's particularly nice of you to go around saying you're the fastest animal if you only run races you think will make you look good.

HARE stares at him for a moment, then bursts into braying laughter.

TORTOISE: What's so funny?

HARE: Oh, Turtle! Are you challenging me to a race?

TORTOISE: Well, I--

HARE: Well, if you insist! Next Saturday. Two o'clock, by the Big Tree. I'll handle the media, you worry about training.

TORTOISE: Training?

HARE: *(suddenly menacing)* Worry about it. *(sweetly)* Goodbye, Turtle.

HARE jogs off, waving at the crowd.

TORTOISE watches her go, then:

TORTOISE: Oh dear. Well, I suppose I'm going to need some running shoes.

He starts off.

ACT I

SCENE 2

A shoe store. The walls have lots of shoe racks and prices, but no actual shoes to speak of. The proprietor of the store is PIG.

PIG: Welcome to Pig's Sports Shoes! Top quality shoes for every foot, hoof, trotter, flipper, or tentacle. Webbed toes a specialty.

PIG has a bit of back-and-forth with the audience, checking their shoes and making recommendations.

There is a jingly-bell noise. PIG looks up expectantly and waits until TORTOISE enters.

PIG: Can I help you?

TORTOISE: Hullo. I need some shoes.

PIG: Well, you've certainly come to a shoe store! Any particular style of shoe I can help you with?

TORTOISE: Running shoes.

PIG: I'm sorry.

TORTOISE: *(louder)* Running shoes.

PIG: No, I mean: I'm sorry. We don't have anything in stock at the moment.

TORTOISE: Jogging shoes?

PIG: Nothing.

TORTOISE: Track shoes?

PIG: Nada.

TORTOISE: Athletic shoes?

PIG: None.

TORTOISE: Sneakers?

PIG: Zip.

TORTOISE: Trainers?

PIG: Zilch.

TORTOISE: Cross-trainers?

PIG: Zero.

TORTOISE: Any actual sports shoes at all?

PIG: Not to speak of, no.

TORTOISE: But this is a sports shoe store. Aren't you supposed to sell sports shoes?

PIG: Yes! And we've been doing exceptionally well at it. So well, in fact, that we've sold out of all our stock. Ever since Hare won that race against Cheetah last week, and became the official Fastest Animal Around, everyone's been getting into running. It's the Hot New Thing!

TORTOISE: What about her race against Tortoise?

PIG: Obviously, that's just a formality. Tortoise hasn't got a chance.

TORTOISE: I'm Tortoise.

PIG: R-really? I thought you were a Turtle.

TORTOISE: It's a common mistake. Turtles are--

PIG: Anyway, what I meant to say was, "Tortoise hasn't got a chance of losing that race". You're a... a shoe-in! Ha! Ha!

TORTOISE: But you said--

PIG: OK, yes, but I was confused. Must've been thinking of... Turtle.

TORTOISE is suspicious.

TORTOISE: Are you just trying to make me feel better about the race?

PIG: ...maybe?

TORTOISE: Look, Pig, I know I'm not going to win the race. I'm just trying to make a point. Hare's

become so caught up in being famous that she doesn't care about anyone else.

PIG: You're not wrong, Tortoise. I sold her her very first pair of shoes, you know that? Came in here with her dad when she was just a leveret, and bought a pair of Pumas. Of course, a year or so later she beat Puma and got her own sponsorship deal. Haven't really seen her since. But those early days... you could tell she really cared about the sport, you know? Now, it's like all she cares about is...

TORTOISE: ...being the best. I know.

PIG: Tortoise, you have to win this race.

TORTOISE: But how? I've never run in my life! I don't have any shoes, and the race is next week!

PIG shuffles uncomfortably.

TORTOISE: What?

PIG: When did you see Hare?

TORTOISE: This afternoon, just after her race with Cheetah. Why?

PIG: And you came straight here?

TORTOISE: I wanted to get started straight away.

PIG: Tortoise, that race was nearly a week ago. It's taken you five days to walk here from your house!

TORTOISE: I wondered why it kept getting dark.

PIG: The race is tomorrow!

TORTOISE: Oh.

PIG: "Oh" is right! Tortoise, I want you to have these.

PIG produces a shoe box from under the counter.

TORTOISE: What are they?

PIG: They're my old shoes. You wouldn't think it to look at me, but I used to run, you know. Hare and I used to go running together. Before it was "cool". And you look about the right size. What are you, a nine?

TORTOISE: Thanks, Pig, but I really don't have a chance now. The race is tomorrow, and I don't even know how to run!

PIG: I think I know how we can fix that, Tortoise. Put on the shoes. It's time for... a TRAINING MONTAGE!

Exciting training music begins to play. The transitions from one exercise to the next should be as sharp as possible, possibly with lighting cues, to give the impression of a montage.

PIG reaches down to touch his toes. TORTOISE draws his legs up inside his shell so that his toes are just sticking out and he can easily reach them with his fingertips. PIG admonishes TORTOISE, who reluctantly does it properly. Next exercise!

Side stretches! TORTOISE stretches so far to the side that he overbalances. PIG rushes to help him. Next exercise!

Star jumps! It takes TORTOISE a few goes to get the arms and legs in sync. Next exercise!

TORTOISE: Push-ups? Why am I (oof!) doing push-ups?

PIG: That's how you know it's a real training montage. The push-ups.

TORTOISE: My arms hurt!

PIG: Not as much as your feelings will hurt when Hare wins that race tomorrow. Thirty-eight. Deeper! Thirty-nine.

Next exercise!

PIG demonstrates "knees-up" running style. TORTOISE kind of hops from foot to foot. Next exercise!

Carbo-loading! TORTOISE eats a big bowl of pasta. Next!

Back to touching toes. TORTOISE is doing pretty well. Next!

Side stretches, for real! Next!

Star jumps! Next!

Push-ups! TORTOISE is a machine! Next!

More running! TORTOISE runs a kind of circle around the stage and finishes with his back to the audience, arms raised, legs apart, head thrown back, in the classic Rocky pose. PIG gently turns him around so that he's facing the audience, panting. The music ends.

TORTOISE: Is that it? Am I ready for the race?

PIG: Almost. You should get a good night's sleep, Tortoise. Take my bed.

TORTOISE: Are you sure? My house is just over--

PIG: I insist. I'll be back in a little while: I've just got to go and make some final arrangements for tomorrow.

PIG starts to leave.

TORTOISE: Pig?

PIG: Yes, tortoise?

TORTOISE: Thanks for helping me. Sorry I'm not going to be any good tomorrow.

PIG: Tortoise, whatever happens tomorrow, I'm proud of you. Goodnight, Tortoise.

TORTOISE: Goodnight, Pig.

There is a jingly-bell sound as PIG

exits.

*TORTOISE turns out the light and
shuffles off to bed.*

REVIEW COPY

ACT I

SCENE 3

Late at night, PIG knocks on HARE's door. HARE opens it, carrying a fancy drink, and loud music and party noises spill out onto the stage. She sees PIG, and steps out, pulling the door closed behind her.

HARE: Hello, Pig.

PIG: Hello, Hare. I see you're taking it easy before the big race tomorrow.

HARE: Just a little gathering with some of my closest friends, Pig. It's hardly like I'm going to need to be in peak physical condition to beat little old Turtle.

PIG: Tortoise.

HARE: What do you want, Pig?

PIG: I want you to do me a favour, Hare. For old times' sake.

HARE: Oh yes? And what's that?

PIG: I want you to lose the race tomorrow.

HARE bursts out laughing.

PIG: Tortoise needs it much more than you do. He's been working so hard.

HARE: All afternoon? I've been running my whole life, Pig.

PIG: Because you've always been fast! You haven't really had to work for it in years. Tortoise has. And, OK, he's still not what you'd call fast. But he's got a good heart.

HARE: You really care about Tortoise, don't you?

PIG: I do. He reminds me of someone I knew once. Someone who saw something she wanted and put everything she had into achieving it. Someone noble, and humble, and kind.

HARE realises who he means.

HARE: I'll give him a head start, Pig. For old times' sake. But that's it. If he can't win from there, then... well, I have my public to think about.

PIG: Of course.

PIG holds out a trotter; HARE shakes it.

Thanks, Hare.

HARE: Goodnight, Pig. And good luck.

PIG: You too.

HARE goes back to the party.

PIG looks around nervously, then hurries off.

ACT I

SCENE 4

*The next afternoon, by the Big Tree.
HARE waits at the starting line,
occasionally checking her watch.*

*The 'running' could be engineered by
having TORTOISE run in place in the
middle of the stage as various items
of scenery are moved across in
parallax by stagehands.*

*Commentary for this scene is
provided by FOX and CROW.*

FOX: Well, good afternoon, everyone, and welcome to this very special race day broadcast. I'm Fox, and joining me in the commentary box today is Crow. Good afternoon, Crow. Shaping up to be a rather unusual match-up, wouldn't you say?

CROW: Thanks, Fox. Yes, on the one hand you have Hare, Fastest Animal Around, fresh from last Saturday's big win over Cheetah, and she of course is up against Tortoise, a relative unknown and, as far as anyone can make out, a total newcomer to the sport.

FOX: Yes, I've certainly never heard of Tortoise in running circles. Tell me, Crow, I've always wondered: what is the difference between a Tortoise and a Turtle?

CROW: Well, it's actually quite simple, Fox: a Turtle is--

TORTOISE arrives.

FOX: I'm afraid I'm going to have to interrupt you there, Crow, as it seems Tortoise has just arrived. He's waving there to his coach, Pig, who I understand has been putting Tortoise through his paces to get him ready for the big race.

CROW: That's right, Fox: we're getting reports of some very intense last-minute training going on in the Tortoise camp. But will it be enough to beat Hare?

FOX: Well, that, of course, is the question on

everyone's lips, beaks, snouts, muzzles, and maws, as the two competitors take their positions on the line.

HARE takes her marks as she's done thousands of times before. TORTOISE watches and copies her.

FOX: And they're under starter's orders...

HARE and TORTOISE mime "set", and wait for the pistol.

There is a loud crack.

The race proceeds as you might expect. TORTOISE takes an early lead, while HARE stands at the starting line looking bored and impatient. Just as TORTOISE begins to look promising, HARE blasts past him and out of sight.

TORTOISE plods on implacably, and eventually catches up to HARE, and this continues for some time, with HARE letting TORTOISE do just well enough that he doesn't just give up, but always staying in the lead, her taunts becoming more and more blatant until she is literally running circles around TORTOISE.

Just as this is becoming unbearable, PIG rides up on a little scooter and interposes himself.

PIG: JUST STOP!

HARE and TORTOISE just stop.

PIG: This is getting ridiculous. Hare, I'm ashamed of you.

HARE: What? I gave Turtle the head start, just like you asked. If he's too slow even to --

TORTOISE: Wait: you asked Hare to give me a head start?

HARE: He asked me to lose the race.

TORTOISE: You what?

PIG: Look, Tortoise: you never had a chance against Hare.

TORTOISE: You said you were proud of me!

PIG: I'm proud of how hard you worked yesterday, Tortoise. But one day's training? Hare's been running for years, not to mention the hundreds of thousands of generations of athletic leporine ancestry...

TORTOISE AND HARE:

...of what?

PIG: Running's in her blood, Tortoise. Hares are built for speed. Tortoises are built for... Well, I just don't understand why you wanted a race with Hare in the first place.

TORTOISE: Hare wins races all the time and now she's famous and important and she throws fancy parties every weekend and everyone likes her.

PIG and HARE stare at him.

And, you know, she was being kind of mean about it.

HARE opens her mouth to protest.

PIG: Quiet, Hare. Tortoise, Hare's famous for running because she's good at it. What are you good at?

TORTOISE: Running.

PIG: What are you good at?

TORTOISE: Running!

PIG: What are you actually good at?

TORTOISE: I make really good marmalade?

This is not quite what PIG was expecting.

PIG: You do?

TORTOISE: Sure! It's an old family recipe.

PIG: Well, there's something, right there! I bet Hare's never made a jar of marmalade in her life!

HARE: I love marmalade.

PIG: But have you ever stood for hours, stirring a big pot full of it on the stove so it doesn't stick and burn?

HARE: Don't be ridiculous. Who has that kind of patience?

TORTOISE: I do.

PIG: Tortoise does. Everyone has things they're good at and things they're not good at. Grasshopper's a fantastic musician, but he sucks at planning ahead. Crow's always coming up with clever plans, but she's a terrible judge of character. And Tortoise might not be a fast runner, but he's patient, and kind, and he has a good heart.

HARE: Whatever. Look, I could be good at anything if I wanted. I just don't have time to stand around all day listening to other people's feelings. I've got a victory party to get ready for.

HARE turns and exits, away from the direction she's been running in.

TORTOISE: She's really not very nice, is she?

PIG: People who are used to being the centre of attention usually aren't.

They start to walk off in the opposite direction.

PIG: Tortoise?

TORTOISE: Yes, Pig?

PIG: There's something I've been meaning to ask. What exactly is the difference between a turtle and a tortoise?

TORTOISE: Well, it's quite simple, actually. Turtles spend most of their lives in the water...

TORTOISE absently ducks under a piece of white tape that has appeared in his path.

...and tortoises spend most of their lives on the land.

PIG is staring at the tape, stunned.

PIG: You... You did it!

TORTOISE: Like I said, it's a pretty simple explanation.

PIG: No, look! Behind you! The finish line!

TORTOISE: Is that what that was? I've never seen a finish line before.

PIG: Of course you haven't! But look! You've --

FOX darts in with a microphone in hand.

FOX: Tortoise has won the race!

HARE comes rushing back in.

HARE: He's what?

PIG AND FOX: HE'S WON THE RACE.

HARE: What? No! That's impossible! I'm much faster! Everyone knows it! You'll be hearing from my lawyer, Pig!

HARE continues ranting.

TORTOISE: I think we just found something Hare's not good at.

PIG: What's that?

TORTOISE: Losing.

PIG and TORTOISE start to laugh, but then notice that HARE has sat down and is taking off her shoes.

PIG: Hare?

HARE ignores him.

TORTOISE: What are you doing?

HARE: What does it look like I'm doing?

TORTOISE: Taking off your shoes?

PIG: But why?

HARE: My running days are over!

PIG and TORTOISE are stunned.

HARE: I mean, I lost a race to Tortoise.

PIG: Sure, but only on a technicality!

TORTOISE: Look, I'll... un-win?

He picks up the tape and tries to walk backwards under it.

HARE sniffles a bit.

HARE: It's no good. I'm finished. Just another washed-up old has-been.

TORTOISE: Hey! Don't talk like that about yourself.

HARE: You don't understand, Tortoise. I lost a race!

TORTOISE: I think I do, Hare. You've been winning races so long you've forgotten how hard you trained to get where you are. I bet you used to lose races all the time when you were starting out.

HARE: But --

TORTOISE: But nothing! You can't let one race destroy your confidence like this.

HARE: But if I'm not the Fastest Animal Around anymore, who's going to want to be my friend?

TORTOISE: I am.

PIG: I am.

TORTOISE: We all are. Hare, it doesn't matter whether you're the Fastest Animal Around, or the Tallest, or the Sleepiest, or the Hungriest!

The only thing that matters is that you do your best to be the Best Animal You Can Be.

He helps HARE to her feet.

HARE: Thanks, Tortoise.

She hugs him.

HARE: Hey, Tortoise? Do you still have that photo of yourself?

TORTOISE pulls out the photo.

TORTOISE: Sure, but... why? I thought you said animals only wanted other animals' photographs if they were famous.

HARE: I think my exact words were "famous, important, and highly regarded".

This takes a moment to sink in.

TORTOISE: Oh. Oh! Gosh.

HARE: You're very important to me, Tortoise, and I regard you very highly.

PIG: And famous? Heck, you just beat Hare in a running race!

HARE and TORTOISE shoot him a Look.

PIG: ...which I'm sure everyone will forget about in no time at all.

HARE puts her shoes back on.

HARE: You want to come for a run tomorrow?

TORTOISE: No, thank you. But how about a picnic?

HARE: Only if you bring the marmalade sandwiches.

TORTOISE: Deal.

There is probably a little song.

Then it is...

THE END